



Software Engineering in the Agentic Era

An industry conversation on how AI is changing the role

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30+ years in software engineering, architecture & design

From Autocomplete to Autonomy

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Autocomplete suggestions & chat-based Q&A (early Copilot-era tools)

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Multi-file edits, chat-driven pair programming

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Coding agents move from experimental tools to production systems

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Agents take on larger chunks of implementation, coordinate with one other

Current State



AI can wield CLIs better than the humans who built them



Context rot is real — long chat threads lose quality as they grow



Spec-driven development & matching the model to the task are now common practice



My biggest complaint about AI is its inability to surface epistemic uncertainty.

— a working senior software engineer, 2026

Discuss: What does “epistemic uncertainty” mean, in plain English?

Has an AI tool ever given you a confidently wrong answer? How did you find out?

The Cost of Not Knowing



LLMs can state their assumptions when asked, but don't seem to have the judgment to tell a small assumption from a big one.



“Verification ensures you are building the product right, while validation ensures you are building the right product.” Which one is AI actually good at?



The QA bottleneck: more code produced means more to review. (Echoes medicine — cheaper imaging → more scans → radiologists struggling to keep up.)



Jevons Paradox: faster code creation doesn't save time — it relocates the burden into exhausting, forensic code review.
NOTE: See <https://typesafe.ai> (Jev, “first public System One Model”)

Directing, Not Chatting



“Directing AI software development agents is like directing an enthusiastic senior engineer that never rests.”

I am a programmer
assisted by an agent



The agent is a programmer
assisted by me



I am a programmer using
an agent to be more efficient

Which stage best describes where you are right now? In a year?

Be the Human.

Use your technical judgment. Don't just approve everything.

Who Trains the Next Generation?

Where will the new senior engineers come from?



"New devs don't have as many battle scars..."



"...but there's never been a better time to learn design patterns & architecture."

"Coding might become a commodity, but technical judgment will not."

Be the Engineer.

Stay close to the code. Stay technically grounded.

The Human Cost



AI Psychosis

Becoming irrationally enthusiastic about AI and losing the ability to evaluate it objectively.



“High-volume AI-based development is exhausting because I have to constantly make decisions, hard decisions, all day long.”

What are the warning signs that a person or a whole team has crossed the line?

Picks and Shovels



“If I can build a given application in a weekend, so can anybody else.”

The most successful software companies today are the toolmakers, not the consumers.

Lightning Round — true in 3 years?

- Software becomes disposable — rebuilt rather than maintained
- Small language models overtake ever-larger frontier models
- “Bring-your-own-AI” becomes commonplace
- Tokens become a priced, tradeable commodity

Thank You

Questions & Discussion

Be the Human. Be the Engineer.

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